# Before you start

## A learning path, not documentation

This is an interactive learning path for beginners and intermediate users of QGIS. It starts from zero: you don't need any prior knowledge of GIS.

The learning path builds up your skills step by step, instead of covering each topic in full detail at once. For example, 'Data in GIS' is covered in two parts: the basics early on, and other kinds of data in a later chapter. It is advised to follow the chapters in order.

The learning path is not documentation: it does not explain every button or option of QGIS. For that, we refer to the QGIS documentation.

## Finding your way

- **Images:** click an image to enlarge it.
- **Links:** where a topic is also covered on another page, the text links to that page.
- **Search:** use the search box at the top of the menu to find a term.

## Styles in the text

- **Red letters**, such as A or B2, match a label on a screenshot on the same page.
- **Menu paths** have a light blue background. *Project* ▸ *Save As…* means: in the *Project* menu, choose *Save As…*
- **Buttons, tabs and other items** in the QGIS window are in *italics*.
- **Names of layers and fields and values in a field** are in a `code font`.

## Tips and points of attention

Some information is shown in a coloured box:

> Tip
>
> A tip: a handy shortcut, a useful option or an extra explanation.

> Warning
>
> Pay attention: a common mistake, or something that is easy to miss.

## Exercises and datasets

You find the exercises and the datasets in a separate part at the end of the learning path: appendix A (Exercises) and appendix B (Datasets).

**Exercises:** as soon as you have learned enough to do an exercise, the learning path points you to it with this box:

> Note
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> You can now do Exercise 1, parts A and B.

Larger exercises are split into parts (A, B, …). At the top of each part you see after which chapter you can do it.

Every exercise also has a solution: a model answer on a separate page, right under the exercise in the menu. Use it to check your work, or to get going again when you are stuck.

**Datasets:** each dataset has its own page, with a download link or a reference to the data on the website of the data provider. A purple box shows which dataset you need, for example at the top of an exercise:

> Note
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> **Dataset:** Roman Empire Infrastructure